Gargoyle

By Joyce Carol Oates

INTRODUCTION

What to make of loneliness. Can you imagine? Aloneness. Loneliness isn't fashionable. It isn't considered a subject one can talk about. "Gargoyle" by Joyce Carol Oates

Three-fifteen a.m. and you lie spread-eagled in bed in your cocoon of a bed in your ripe swollen cocoon of a body while I drive through the snowy drizzle querying myself about life.

Driving along a deserted boulevard. Yellow street lights high atop slender poles. Rain, snow. Mist. Wind. What to make of loneliness. Not anger, not rage, not the wish to die or even the wish to murder. I'm too exhausted for all that. Just loneliness. What to make of it. Aloneness. Can you hear me? Can you guess? Never. You are eight months pregnant now and lie sleepless beside my lover, your spine aching, your stomach bloated, you are a beached bewildered mammalian creature gasping in the air. Can you guess at me? Never. But do you sense me, do you fear me?

Three-sixteen a.m. on a Friday morning, or do I mean a Thursday night. I drive too fast, and then slow down, skidding on a patch of ice a quarter-mile from your bed. My loneliness has turned sinister. I can't be trusted. Your husband sleeps beside you and in the confused instant of waking he could not know—he could not possibly know—which woman lies with him beneath the covers. Suppose he smells the sweet-stale odor of blood, what then? His face would stiffen with disapproval and even with disgust but he could not know who lay close beside him in the night. Your husband. My lover.

What to make of aloneness in the slowly falling snow. In the bluish dusk of a city's night. I know your house well and I have even visited your bedroom and your bed and I know how

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you lie awake, your eyes burning, not allowing yourself to think of me. It's difficult to find a comfortable position in that bed. Not only is your stomach so swollen—a little too big, in fact, for an eight-months' pregnancy—but the mattress sags toward the center. You don't want to press against your husband because you might wake him and his personality, introduced into the night, will injure it. He's breathing harshly, with chortling gasping sounds. His sleep isn't easy, isn't restful. He has never lied to you. Of course not. You with three children and a fourth imminent and your head crowded with visions: you are never lonely. Never. If you could imagine me driving alone on Maidstone Avenue at three-twenty a.m., smoking my cigarettes and talking to myself, and singing snatches of half-remembered songs, you would feel only pity. And if you could guess that I was dramatizing my condition, working it into an interesting anecdote I might someday (not soon: but someday) tell my lover—how you might laugh, scornfully, and with slight hysteria. Suppose I told him. And he listened attentively enough, and then flushed with embarrassment. And irritation. My melodic laughter. My slender pretty inconsequential face. Or am I pretty?

You are rather ugly these days. Sallow-skinned, with dark pouches beneath your eyes like bruises. This fourth pregnancy (which was whose idea?—surely not his) is nearly as difficult as the first. But you aren't going to be frightened. You aren't going to wonder if it was a mistake. . . . Three weeks pregnant; and then two months; and then five; and six; and seven; and eight. A wide dark river carried you along with it. If you sat gasping for breath at the top of the stairs, your knuckles pressed against your mouth, you never told anyone; nor did you tell anyone about your dread of the upcoming birth. Nor about the crazy fear during the first several months that you would miscarry, or would arrange for an abortion, carried along like a woman in a dream.

You haven't been lonely for years, have you. Not since your marriage. Why do you keep so much from your husband, don't you trust him? He doesn't love you but, of course, he's very fond of you. He still approves of your appearance: that sturdy strong-boned flesh of yours,

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the face of a Flemish peasant who is *almost* beautiful. When he looks at you, you shy away, not wanting him to see the shadows beneath your eyes, the death-mask, the slightly twisted, sullen, mad mouth. *I no longer love her but I'm very fond of her*, he said. *I'm deeply committed to her.*

I think about you, lying there in your bed. I think about myself driving along the empty streets seeking knowledge. And adventure, perhaps. I wonder—didn't you ever smell me on him? My hair, my skin, my body? There were times when we lay pressed together for hours, our skins sleekly wet, our eyelashes touching. *Little whore*, he whispered fondly, admiringly. *Aren't you a little whore.*

Once you stared at him and saw the awed, sickened love in his face, the web of his thoughts stuck close against his skin. What are you thinking about, you might have asked, uneasily. Sullenly. What are you making faces at—! He glanced up at you guiltily. Your eyes met in shame. Are you beginning to sense me now?

Driving east along Flat Rock Avenue. Three-twenty-five a.m. The pill's famous effect is generated out of one's resistance to it: staying conscious while the drug urges unconsciousness. Shadowy arms reach up to pull me down but I resist. Not yet. Not yet. The car's wheels turn of their own volition onto a side street where the snow seems to be falling more thickly than elsewhere. What to make of loneliness. Aloneness.

The fashion today, which you and I both read about in women's magazines, is independence. The joys of living alone. Autonomy. Or maybe the fashion is to dwell upon the sporadic loneliness within a family, within (even) a marriage. Crap. Glamorous crap. I am talking about the real thing. Which you know nothing about, you with your three adorable children and your bloated stomach and the life kicking within it, and your snoring husband at your side.

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Loneliness isn't fashionable. It isn't considered a subject one can talk about. There are people who brag about living alone, who speak in public about the joys of aloneness, but they fall silent if someone asks them about loneliness. *The Well of Loneliness. Loneliness. The Well of.* Never read the novel. Paged through it years ago, in high school. Struck by the title. *Loneliness: The Well of.* You wouldn't know because you have not fallen into that well. You wouldn't know because you are stuffed with life like a sausage filled to bursting. You wouldn't know because you tell so many lies, even to yourself.

The snow is mixed with grit. I don't know why. The windshield wipers leave a scummy glaring mess.

You heave yourself from bed, gasping. My lover murmurs but does not wake. Thank God. His hoarse labored breathing begins again. Barefoot you stand beside the bed in the faint light from the window, uneasy, puzzled. You cannot *quite* see me. Once when you stared at your husband's face, at his sad cunning hooded eyes, you caught a glimpse of a face: a ghostly face; but in the next instant it vanished. What are you thinking about, you asked him sullenly. The fear began then but you never acknowledged it.

I am driving north now along a narrow street called Railway. It intersects with your street, as you know. I am not drunk, I am not high, I am perfectly sane. Wide awake for the second night, in fact. Wide awake. The bars are closed and there is nothing to do but drive and call to you, whisper to you. That heavy trembling in your belly—do you suppose I can't feel it? That panic that rises in you, rankly powerful as an odor of something foul, and secret—do you suppose I don't understand it? You don't approve, do you? Drawing your arm across your sweaty forehead, standing with your legs apart, your toes curling upon the floor.

My second night without sleep. Or is it the third.

What to make of loneliness—what *is* it, exactly? Do you know?

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A few weeks ago an extraordinary compulsion came over you and you sat in the kitchen alone, in secret, and ate bread: piece after piece. You were ravenous. You didn't smear butter or jam on the bread but simply ate it piece after piece. Your jaws ground. *It* drew upon you, *it* demanded nourishment at once. Everything was distant to you at that time, during those bizarre forty-five minutes—your children, your husband, your own individual life. You were utterly alone with the baby-to-be. You were utterly alone with its appetite.

I think that would have frightened me—the realization that another being pulsed along my veins, and that I was subordinate to it. That I did not exist, maybe. Not as I liked to think.

The stubborn clotted bit of flesh was expelled from *my* body. I didn't succumb to it. How many years of love, you are wondering.

Making your way clumsily downstairs, lowering yourself from step to step with caution, not wanting the stairs to squeak. Are you hungry again? Headed for the refrigerator again? Pale sick trembling ghoulish woman! Someone's arms rise to pull you down, you shudder and arch your back, resisting. No. Not yet. Not here. One by one lights in the brain go out, extinguished for the night, and the trick is to resist keeling over. What are you listening for, at the foot of the stairs?

What to make of loneliness. Like old clothes, old shoes. You can't wear them but you can't throw them out either. You *can't* wear them. No matter how costly they were or how you liked them at one time. Dresses so short they might have belonged to grammar school girls, or hat check girls. (The dress of white wool that your husband liked: holding my face and talking fancifully of winter, snow, he and I isolated somewhere together, wolves baying in the distance. A forlorn crescent moon, the anguish of kisses that will come to nothing, the glamour of the unattainable. I examined the dress critically, saw that the inside of the skirt was stained, a stiff milkish stain. I must have put the dress away at the back of the closet without sending it out to be cleaned, as if I knew I'd never wear it again.)

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Your breasts hang heavy inside your nightgown. They are uncomfortably large, with soft brown nipples. Your legs ache. In the darkened house you stand on guard, your eyes fairly bulging in their sockets. Surely you are not afraid of *me* . . . ?

I wonder, though, why you never guessed. Those years. The odor of my body must have been carried home to you many times. Your husband isn't a very fastidious man, he showers several times a week, of course, but isn't exceptionally clean, and the odor of my desperation must have come to you. Or are you too ignorant to understand? I don't think you are ignorant at all. I think you are very wise.

Those sessions of love-making in his car. By the river, high above the river. For months afterward I dreamt of the hundred-foot drop, the muffled noise of the river, the curious wailing of the wind. A wide river, a steep incline. Wooded bluffs across the way. In his arms I clutched and wept, knowing he would let me go, knowing he hadn't the strength to hold me as I fell. Falling down, down into the warm, thick liquid, the two of us struggling, gagging—always I was falling as the edge crumples, pitched into air, into nothing. Into that warm suffocating liquid that is so terrifying. And then I awake: sometimes there is a dull ache in my loins, an ache of sexual distress; sometimes there is only a sensation of loss, of numbness. Do you fall in your sleep too, knowing his arms won't hold you—won't support you? I drove out there one afternoon last week. For no reason. For the hell of it. Someone was parked there, in the very place my lover and I used to park. I wanted to tap on the window and ask: Is it good for you two here? Don't you know the danger? The height—the river—the wind—the loneliness.

He didn't lie. I don't think they were lies. I think he believed them. I was the princess, he said; I was beautiful. He was in love. You, of course, were the third party, the excluded one: to be pitied, to be scorned. But taken seriously. (For you were suicidal, he claimed.) What a silly woman, I said, hearing of my rival's behavior. He showed me a snapshot of you,

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reluctantly, and I said nothing at all, though my eyes curled with contempt. *That* face. *Those* eyes. How had she deserved so fine a man—! He enumerated your flaws: your moods, your bad temper, your messiness, your jealousy. Your nervousness.

Once in a second-hand jewelry and antique store on lower Main Street your husband and I prowled amidst tarnished candlestick holders and lacquered chests of drawers and cedar-lined trunks from the early 1900's and rickety chairs and tables, and lamps, and vases, and untidy displays of chinaware, some of it very beautiful. But damaged. He offered to buy me a statuette of a puckish, rather battered Cupid. He was a little drunk. From wine. From lunch. From love. Maybe from the excitement of betraying *you*.

"Is that a gargoyle?" I asked.

"It's a Cupid," your husband said. "A misshapen Cupid. See, his wings are gone—they were broken off."

We laughed over the thing. Love made us dizzy. Daring. Rather cruel. (For the salesman stood watching us patiently and we ignored him.) I turned the carving from side to side. It was a toad-like grimacing creature, about three feet tall, sly and lecherous yet, at the same time, babyish. What *was* it, I wanted suddenly to know. *Who* could have labored over such a monstrosity.

"The artist was serious, evidently," your husband said. "Look at the detail here around the eyes."

"He couldn't have been serious," I said.

One eye was screwed up in a gay bawdy knowing wink, and the other was wide-open and bulging. What did it *mean*, I wondered, surprised at its weight. There was something icy and shrewd about the Cupid's expression, yet he remained an infant; he was infantile. His monstrousness was not his fault.

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"I hate it," I whispered.

Your husband was in fine spirits that day. He was not just a husband but a lover as well. His girl was a princess, his girl was beautiful, she was impregnable and exalted and slender as you were not, and near-virginal as, of course, you were not. Her breasts were small and hard, her nipples tiny, her belly flat and smooth, very smooth. Her legs were long. Her eyes often flashed. There was no one quite like her: she was remarkably *young*.

I walked quickly away into another part of the store. The Cupid did not amuse me.

My lover followed along behind me and took hold of my waist and kissed the side of my cheek. I smelled wine on his breath. "You love me, don't you," my lover whispered.

Barefoot at the bottom of the stairs you stand in your darkened house, your hands pressed on your enormous belly. Across the street a porch light burns. Snow falls in random spasmodic puffs. You do not allow yourself to think of my lover, who groaned aloud with passion in my arms, as if passion would kill him. As if no one had ever experienced passion before. You do not allow yourself to think of me, though I am driving along your street now, slowly, fearful of skidding on the ice.

Your belly is stretched to bursting. Bluish-white. You stagger with your own weight, a woman with a noble profile, a ravaged skin. I, who am empty inside, who was scraped empty inside, do not envy you. I would be afraid to be you, in fact. *I've never been unfaithful*, your husband says coldly. He stares at you, daring you to guess. He hates you, fears you, lives in awe of you.

Once he shook me by the shoulders, hard, blaming me for your unhappiness. *Little whore*, he whispered, *what do you want from me . . . ?*

I park at the curb, I leave the car cautiously, afraid of slipping on the ice. Who is that at the door, peering through the window of the door, watching for me? Why are you so still,

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so ghostly? In the street light I appear to you, a woman in a long dark coat and boots, moving like a sleepwalker. My arms outstretched. Are you going to let me in? Do you recognize me at last? I make my way cautiously to your front door and put out my hand, as if to ring the doorbell. But I don't ring the bell: I merely press my fingertips against the window. And you, inside, in the warm slumberous depths of the house, hesitate only a moment before putting out your hand as well, so that our fingertips meet—nearly meet—through the glass.

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